

Last time we introduced the question of what we should believe. We began by considering this rule of belief:

No Proof $\rightarrow$ No Belief

If you can't give a good
argument for P, don't
believe P.

But we saw that this led to the result that you should not believe anything at all, which seems very implausible.

At the very least, it seems, we should believe things that we can be certain of:

Certainty $\rightarrow$ Belief

If you can rule out any situation which would make P false, you should believe P.

Experience → Belief

If your sense experience tells you that P, and you have no reason to think that your sense experience is misleading, you should believe P.

Proof $\rightarrow$ Belief

If you can prove
P, you should
believe P.

This is a version of a view known as foundationalism.

It can be summed up with the following negative rule of belief:

No Foundations → No Belief

If you can't be certain that P and your senses don't tell you that P and you can't give a good argument for P, you should not believe P.

We have encountered this idea twice already in this course. One place it came up was in the following argument against the existence of immaterial souls:

1. We have no sensory experience of immaterial souls.
2. You can't be certain that there are immaterial souls.
3. We have no good argument for the existence of immaterial souls.
4. If you can't be certain that P and your senses don't tell you that P and you don't have a good argument for P, you should not believe P.

C. You should not believe in the existence of immaterial souls. (1,2,3,4)

THE EVIDENTIALIST ARGUMENT AGAINST BELIEF IN IMMATERIAL SOULS

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